
ACTOR PART BOOK

Player 2

the diva and the props

Six Characters in Search of an Author

Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

50 SPEECHES · 492 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY

WHO PLAYER 2 IS

Carries the Leading Lady, the Property Man, the Fourth Actor, and the Second Lady Lead. **About thirty-five — and the real working professional Player 1 only impersonates.** She is some years younger than him and a great deal better at the job: she has already played leads at the Lausanne houses — a Marivaux at the Vidy, a Beckett at the Pulloff they still talk about — and she has had drinks with everyone on the cantonal arts council at some point. She is not the eldest in the room; she is the one who actually books the work, season after season, while the older man beside her recites the career he meant to have. She does not need to say so. Her authority is in her shoulders, not her years.

She plays four roles, but always as herself, just as Player 1 does. Her **Leading Lady** is weary, slightly offended, deeply professional — the diva is real, the diva is earned, and at thirty-five she is already a little tired of having to be one. Her **Property Man** is the same woman in a different posture: efficient, no-nonsense, vaguely irritated, the patience the director has personally exhausted. She *chose* to do the props this season because the company could not afford a real Property Man and she was not going to let the show open without a folding screen. She is not ashamed of either register. Both are work. Both are paid in francs.

The transition between the two is in the bearing — chest lifted and chin raised for the Leading Lady, shoulders down and weight forward for the Property Man — and the audience should come to read the flip without any prop signalling it.

The arc to score: in Act One she watches the Six arrive with the patience of a woman who has seen weirder things in this profession. In Act Two the Father asks the actresses for their hats and she gives him hers without a word; then she climbs onto the upper platform to play the Step-Daughter, and is laughed at by a much younger woman who has actually been through the room she is being asked to fake. That laugh is the wound. By the time she says *I have been made a fool of by better*, she means it. She has been. By Act Three she would like to be at home with the cat. She is one of the Players who, by then, knows the play has run away from them and is being polite about it. The hat-rack and the prop trolley are both her territory — and so is the bar afterwards.

THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

What it is. Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

This production. Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen**. One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

How it opens. The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

Act One

PART I *The Rehearsal*

3 SPEECHES · 26 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... — if the house has any left to spare us this evening.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)* [she has been at work for an hour; the Property Man's bearing — shoulders forward, weight on the front foot]. Yes, sir. At once. [A light comes down on to the stage.]

CUE *The Manager:* Fix up the old red room.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)* [noting it down, not looking up]. Red set. [A beat.] Same flats as the blue room. I'll turn them round.

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man):* ... of it, sir, and not one inch built on a cook's cap.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man)* [not looking up from her clipboard]. Fifteen years. And the cap is what finally finishes you.

PART II *The Plea*

9 SPEECHES · 111 WORDS

CUE *Player 3:* Sorry — is this still the rehearsal?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* [not unkindly, eyes front]. Nobody knows, love. Write it all down, and we'll work out later which half was the play.

CUE *Player 3:* ... every word he says. When did anyone here last mean a word?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* [chin up, the diva back; sotto voce to Player 1]. They want to live, in us... as if there were room.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... I can dance and sing. Don't worry — it isn't a hymn.

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Bravo! Well done! Encore!

CUE *The Father:* Quick, a chair, a chair for this poor widow!

ALL THREE PLAYERS. Is it true? Has she really fainted?

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man):* What a spectacle. What an absolute...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)* [lower now]. We are the audience this time.

CUE *The Father:* ... all the evil that can come from good, what would we do?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* Excuse me — *mais sérieusement* — are we going to rehearse today, or have we converted to a lecture series?

CUE *Player 1 (as L'Ingénue):* Most interesting. In a kind of educational way.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* Yes — for the kind of audience that goes in for that kind of evening. The rest of us are working actors. We have rent to pay. [Casts a glance at **LEADING MAN.**]

CUE *The Father*: ... her began gradually to fill the emptiness I felt all around me.

PLAYER 2 [*the back of a script suddenly being used as a notepad*]. Should we be writing this down? Some of it sounds important.

CUE *The Father*: ... have to assume, in a shameful and fleeting moment of my life.

PLAYER 2. Pardon — did we just witness a *confession*?

PART III *The Bargain*

5 SPEECHES · 47 WORDS

CUE *Player 3 (as Juvenile Lead)*: They are not ordinary strangers.

PLAYER 2 (*as Leading Lady*). No. Ordinary strangers do not arrive with a tragedy already rehearsed.

CUE *Player 1*: ... wants us to make a play out of them. In twenty minutes.

PLAYER 2. He once staged the Nativity in fifteen.

CUE *Player 3*: Perhaps there is a play.

PLAYER 2. There is always a play. The question is whether anyone is being paid to be in it.

CUE *Player 1 (as Door-keeper)*: I only let them in.

PLAYER 2. That is not a defence.

CUE *Player 3 (as Prompter)*: Am I taking this down?

PLAYER 2. Take everything down. It may be evidence.

Act Two

PART I *Backstage*

15 SPEECHES · 89 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... and see if there isn't a sofa or divan in the wardrobe...

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man) [the Property Man's voice, flat and certain].* There's the green one. It is the sofa we have. It has always been the sofa we have.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... It was yellow, ornamented with flowers — very large! and most comfortable!

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* There isn't one like that.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... the little table! The little mahogany table for the pale blue envelope!

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man) [to MANAGER].* There's that little gilt one.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... screen! There must be a screen. Otherwise how am I to manage?

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* That's all right, Miss. We've got any amount of them.

CUE *The Manager:* See how many we've got and bring them all.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man) [a half-nod; she is already on her way].* Right.

CUE *The Manager:* ... Clear the stage, ladies and gentlemen! Come over here and listen attentively.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* But, excuse me, we...

CUE *The Manager:* What is there to laugh at?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [indignant].* Nobody has ever dared to laugh at me. Nobody. I insist on being treated with respect — and reasonable lighting — otherwise I go.

CUE *The Manager:* You should feel honored to be played by...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [at once, contemptuously].* "That woman there"...

CUE *The Manager:* ... if possible, a pale blue one; and give it to that gentleman.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* An ordinary envelope?

CUE *The Manager and The Father:* Yes, yes, an ordinary envelope.

PLAYER 2 *(as Property Man).* At once, sir. *[Exit.]*

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* How I'll play it, how I'll live it!...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [offended].* I'll live it too, you may be sure, as soon as I begin!

CUE *The Father:* ... be so good as to give me their hats for a moment...

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[half surprised, half laughing, in chorus].*

CUE *The Father:* ... the ladies will be so kind as to take off her mantle...

ALL THREE PLAYERS.

TWO PLAYERS.

CUE *The Father*: ... them up here for a moment. Please be so kind, will you?

ALL THREE PLAYERS *[taking off their hats, one or two also their cloaks, and going to hang them on the racks].*

PART II *The Apparition*

1 SPEECH · 9 WORDS

CUE *Player 3 (as Juvenile Lead)*: ... come from? Not from the SSA list, I can tell you that.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. A vulgar trick. And not even a good one.

PART III *The Substitution*

11 SPEECHES · 149 WORDS

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [the diva fully present; she has done a thousand scenes harder than this]*. Of course. It's easy enough. *[To LEADING MAN.]* Shall you and I try it now?

CUE *The Manager*: ... written out properly after. You remain here... oh, where are you going?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. One minute. I want to put my hat on again. *[Goes over to hat-rack and puts her hat on her head.]*

CUE *The Step-Daughter*: But she isn't dressed in black.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [an appraising look, head tilted, eyes narrowed]*. But I shall be. And much more effectively than you.

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: Good afternoon, Miss.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. Good afternoon.

CUE *The Manager*: Good — but not so heavily. And you say: "No, sir."

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady)*. No, sir.

CUE *The Manager*: Don't stop. Don't stop. We're past the worst of it. Carry on!

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [recovering, back into the rehearsed register]*. No sir... I'll do it myself. *[Removes her hat with the efficient gesture of a woman who has done it a hundred times in front of a mirror.]*

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: ... hat. Come and help me choose one from the stock, won't you?

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [politely demure]*. No thank you, sir.

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: ... you don't. There's always a way round these little matters, you know.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [eyes downcast, on cue]*. It's not the hat, sir. I couldn't wear it because I am — as you see — you might have noticed. *[Touches the front of her dress with the back of her hand.]*

CUE *Player 1 (as Leading Man)*: in mourning. Of course. I beg your pardon. I'm frightfully sorry.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [the rehearsed recovery, voice catching exactly where she has been taught it should catch]*. It's I who must thank you. There's no need for you to feel mortified or specially sorry. Don't think any more of what I've said. I must forget that I am dressed so...

CUE *The Father*: Yes. He said "Oh."

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [breaking character, to MANAGER].* Sir, I cannot work with the originals standing five feet away correcting every breath. Either they sit or I sit.

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* We will not.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [the veteran has had enough — the diva's posture goes from offended to leaving].* I am not going to stand here being made a fool of by that woman. I have been made a fool of — believe me — by considerably better.

Act Three

PART I *The Argument over Reality*

3 SPEECHES · 41 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* ... when the public was up to the level of that child there.

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady).* It makes the illusion easier. The audience needs to know which room we are in. They aren't going to *guess*.

CUE *The Father:* ... thing is only — and rightly so — a kind of game...

PLAYER 2 *(as Leading Lady) [interrupting indignantly].* A *game*? We are serious actors, sir. We have training.

CUE *The Father:* ... of today is fated to seem a mere illusion to you tomorrow?

PLAYER 2 *[whispering].* Is this still the play, or has it become something else?

PART II *The Refusal*

1 SPEECH · 8 WORDS

CUE *The Step-Daughter:* ... him — and I tempted him more than any of the others!

PLAYER 2 *[to Player 1].* I had no idea Pirandello was so chatty.

PART III *The Fountain*

2 SPEECHES · 12 WORDS

CUE *The Manager:* Is he really wounded?

TWO PLAYERS. He's dead! dead!

CUE *Two Players:* He's dead! dead!

THE OTHER PLAYERS. No, no, it's only make believe, it's only pretence!